



INUIT

THE RETURN OF “OUR LAND”

IN 1999 THE CANADIAN GOVERNMENT GAVE BACK part of the Northwest Territories to the Inuit. The new land, called Nunavut, which means “our land,” has been occupied by the Inuit for 4,000 years. For centuries the Inuit lived



IGLOOLIK

Igloolik is a small town on an island in Foxe Basin. In 1932 the Hudson's Bay Trading Company built the town as a trading post and the Inuit were lured away from their nomadic settlements to the Western luxuries of the town. Although Western food, even junk food, is available in Igloolik, the local people still like to rely on meat from the land, such as caribou (wild reindeer), walrus, seal, whale, and birds.

CARIBOU SPOOKS

The Inuit sometimes build a structure, called an *Inukshuk*, on raised ground to help them navigate. They also use it as a caribou spook in the hope that the caribou will think it is a man and run in the opposite direction toward the hunter.



THE IGLOO MYTH

Contrary to popular belief, the Inuit do not live in igloos. The snow houses that we know as igloos are only temporary shelters for hunters. However, igloo actually means “house” in *Inuktitut* so technically they do live in igloos!

LANGUAGE—INUKTITUT

The Inuit language, *Inuktitut*, is widely used in the North with varying dialects. In *Inuktitut* there are 125 different words for snow and ice! This is actually essential when snow conditions are vital for survival.

Inuktitut characters	Inuktitut word	Meaning
ᐱᐅᐅᐅ	aput	snow
ᐱᐅ	siku	ice
ᐱᐅᐅᐅᐅᐅ	qanniq	falling snow
ᐱᐅᐅᐅᐅᐅᐅ	piqsiaq	blowing snow
ᐱᐅᐅᐅᐅᐅᐅᐅ	auviq	snow ideal for igloos

Here are some familiar *Inuktitut* words:

Igloo - house

Anorak - windproof coat

Kayak - long, thin boat suitable for one person



1 Building an igloo

The hunter must find a site containing snow that is perfect for making an igloo. Blocks of snow of the same size are cut using a snow knife.



2 Starting the wall

The skillful builder stands the bottom blocks upright, slightly leaning inward. He shapes and fits each block so that there are no gaps between them.



3 The finished shelter

As the walls rise, the angle of each block increases, and a large fitted cap-block completes the domelike structure.